

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter School Overview

Washington, D.C. — NLRB Jurisdiction — May 2026

NAPCS Unionization Research • May 2026 • Template v8.0

Section 1: State Overview

State	Washington, D.C.
Labor Board	NLRB — National Labor Relations Board — Region 5 (Baltimore/Washington)
Governing Law	National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). All DC Public Charter Schools (PCS) are authorized by the DC Public Charter School Board (DC PCSB) and independently incorporated as private nonprofit employers. DC PERB covers traditional DCPS employees only — PERB(DC) does NOT apply to any DC PCS. All DC charter labor matters are handled by NLRB Region 5.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB Region 5 (Baltimore) is the sole applicable board for all 7 DC NAPCS charter schools. PERB(DC) covers DCPS employees only. This has been clearly established across all 6 certification proceedings in the DC charter school community.
Right-to-Work	NOT a Right-to-Work State — Washington DC is not a right-to-work jurisdiction. DC charter schools are private employers under the NLRA; no DC right-to-work statute exists and the NLRA preempts any such provision. (Union security provisions are available in CBA negotiations for DC charter school unions.)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — NLRB jurisdiction — secret ballot election required. One exception: Mundo Verde Calle Ocho campus added via apparent voluntary employer recognition during COVID (May 2020) — mechanism to be confirmed in next biannual cycle.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — April 2026 — 125 charter schools searched
Research Window	March–April 2026

Section 2: Charter School Landscape

Total charter schools in Washington, D.C.: 125 (Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 125 open DC charter schools as of May 2026 — Registry v59)). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Confirmed Union Schools	7	5.7%	All 7 NAPCS DC schools confirmed. DC Alliance of Charter Teachers and Staff (DC ACTS / AFT) is the organizing entity for all DC confirmed schools. Active CBA: Mundo Verde (2 campuses). First contract in negotiation: Capital City (3 campuses). Post-election: DC International (1). Breakthrough Montessori — certified June 5, 2025 (1).
Total Open DC Charter Schools	125	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25). All 125 DC charter schools are authorized by DC PCSB (Registry v59). 7 of 125 are in the NAPCS research dataset.

Charter School Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	41,833 students — 44.4% of state K–12 enrollment (94,211 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	25,642 students in network-affiliated schools — 61.3% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	4,119 students (9.8% of charter enrollment) — 2,082 in CMO/EMO-affiliated schools (5.0%); 2,037 in independently organized schools (4.9%)
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
KIPP DC	CMO	20	20	—	7,372
Friendship Public Charter Schools	CMO	15	15	—	4,378
AppleTree Early Learning	CMO	8	8	—	658
Center City Public Charter Schools	CMO	6	6	—	1,446
DC Prep	CMO	6	6	—	2,181
Capital City Public Charter School	CMO	3	3	3	1,015
E.L. Haynes Public Charter School	CMO	3	3	—	1,184
Rocketship Public Schools	CMO	3	3	—	1,197
Two Rivers Public Charter School	CMO	3	3	—	1,022
Washington Latin PCS	CMO	3	3	—	1,130
Digital Pioneers Academy PCS	CMO	2	2	—	684
Elsie Whitlow Stokes Community Freedom PCS	CMO	2	2	—	707
Lee Montessori Public Charter School	CMO	2	2	—	544
Mundo Verde Bilingual PCS	CMO	2	2	2	1,067
Paul Public Charter School	CMO	2	2	—	767
LEARN Charter School Network	CMO	1	11	—	290
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Washington, D.C.		81		5	25,642

of which organized (5.0% of charter enrollment)				5	2,082
---	--	--	--	---	-------

Total enrollment shown is the combined enrollment of all CMO/EMO network schools in Washington, D.C.. Organized network schools: 5 organized — 2,082 students in organized network schools (5.0% of total charter enrollment).

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.
‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

16 CMO (nonprofit). Approximately 44 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Charter School Overview

Findings are based on research as of May 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). All DC Public Charter Schools (PCS) are authorized by the DC Public Charter School Board (DC PCSB) and independently incorporated as private nonprofit employers. DC PERB covers traditional DCPS employees only — PERB(DC) does NOT apply to any DC PCS. All DC charter labor matters are handled by NLRB Region 5. Washington, D.C. is not a right-to-work state (Washington DC is not a right-to-work jurisdiction. DC charter schools are private employers under the NLRA; no DC right-to-work statute exists and the NLRA preempts any such provision.). Charter schools in Washington, D.C. are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (NLRB). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.
2: Charter School Structure Washington, D.C. operates 125 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 41,833 students. 16 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Washington, D.C.. The largest networks by campus count are KIPP DC (20 campuses in state), Friendship Public Charter Schools (15 campuses in state), AppleTree Early Learning (8 campuses in state). Approximately 44 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Washington DC charter school labor relations have received focused but limited press coverage, concentrated on three milestone events: the Mundo Verde Calle Ocho voluntary recognition (May 2020), the Capital City Staff Union certification (May 2024, over 80% vote), and the Breakthrough Montessori employer-filed RM petition (May 2025). DC ACTS (dcacts1927.org) is the primary public communications vehicle.

Stakeholder Communications

DC ACTS Local 1927 (dcacts1927.org) maintains a public website documenting all chapter certifications, CBAs, and organizing news. The Mundo Verde CBA (ratified 2023) is publicly posted at dcacts1927.org. Capital City Staff Union first contract ratified August 2025. DC International School first contract bargaining ongoing as of April 2026. Breakthrough Montessori certified June 5, 2025 (05-RM-365867); first contract bargaining commenced June 2025 — status unconfirmed as of May 2026. No documented employer opposition, counter-organizing campaign, or public anti-union statement from any DC PCSB-authorized charter school across all 6 organizing campaigns (May 2019–May 2025). The Breakthrough Montessori employer RM petition (NLRB Case 05-RM-365867, May 2025) is the sole documented employer-initiated labor board action in the DC NAPCS dataset — it resulted in a 48-5 union win (91%), cert issued June 5, 2025.

Legislative Context

All DC charter schools are NLRB-jurisdiction employers (NLRB Region 5, Baltimore/DC). DC has no state public-sector labor law applicable to charter schools. The DC Council is strongly pro-labor but has no direct role in charter labor relations. DC PCSB (authorizer) has taken no public position on charter school unionization.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

NLRB public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Mundo Verde PCS (both campuses)	Mundo Verde Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	Active — CBA ratified 2023 2023 CBA (period TBD — see dcacts1927.org)	dcacts1927.org — CBA posted publicly
Capital City PCS (all 3 campuses)	Capital City Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	Active — first contract ratified August 2025 First contract (August 2025 — period TBD)	dcacts1927.org or school HR
DC International School	DCI Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	In negotiation — first contract not yet ratified as of April 2026 N/A (first contract pending)	dcacts1927.org or school HR
Breakthrough Montessori PCS	Breakthrough Montessori Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	In negotiation — first contract bargaining commenced June 2025; status unconfirmed as of May 2026 N/A (first contract pending)	dcacts1927.org or school HR